that the time decreases when we move from west to east and increases with our westward movement.

17. The world is divided into 24 time zones.

    The 180° line of longitude is approximately where the International Date Line passes. The time at this longitude is exactly 12 hours from the 00 longitude, irrespective of one travels westward or eastward from the Prime Meridian.

    The countries with large east west span may choose more than one standard meridian to get more than one time zone such as Russia, Canada and the United States of America.

18. There is a general understanding among the countries of the world to select the standard meridian in multiples of 7°30' of longitude. That is why 82°30' E has been selected as the 'standard meridian' of India. Indian Standard Time is ahead of Greenwich Mean Time by 5 hours and 30 minutes.

    There are some countries where there are more than one standard meridian due to their vast east-to- west extent. For example, the USA has seven time zones.

19. Soil degradation is the main factor leading to the depleting soil resource base in India. The degree of soil degradation varies from place to place according to the topography, wind velocity and amount of the rainfall.

    Soil erosion is the displacement of the upper layer of soil, it is one form of soil degradation. This natural process is caused by the dynamic activity of erosive agents, that is, water, ice, snow, air, plants, animals, and humans.

    Weathering describes the breaking down or dissolving of rocks and minerals on the surface of the Earth. Water, ice, acids, salts, plants, animals, and changes in temperature are all agents of weathering.

20. Sheet and gully erosions are types of water erosion. Both these are harmful in declining the soil fertility. Water erosion is a more serious and occurs extensively in different parts of India. The country is losing nearly about 8000 hectares of land due to the water erosion.

21. Wind erosion is significant in arid and semi-arid regions. In regions with heavy rainfall and steep slopes, erosion by running